

Meeting 3: Revisions of Research Design and Theory

Operationalization, Variables, Validity, and Reliability
Bachelor Project 2025–2026

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Today's Agenda

1. Where you are this week
2. Operationalization: from concepts to measurement
3. Walking through each project: RQ, equation, operationalisation
4. Privacy forms and next-week deliverables

Where you are this week

Working across the group

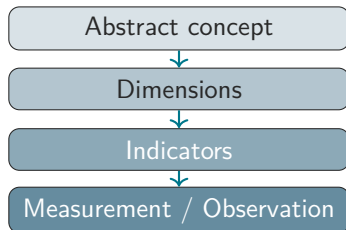
- RQs tighter and more explanatory
- Peer-reviewed literature doing more of the work
- Workable conceptual models in several drafts
- Strong case anchoring (Hungary, Russia, ASEAN, Germany)
- Hypotheses committing to a direction

Still to land for A4

- Operationalisation: a concrete indicator per concept
- Sample frame and time window, in writing
- Privacy checklist for primary-data projects
- Word count on the cover
- One or two of you: the conceptual model, drawn out

What is Operationalization?

Operationalization **translates abstract concepts** into **observable, measurable indicators**. It bridges theory and empirical research.



Operationalization: An Example

Concept: Algorithmic management

Dimensions (Wood et al., 2019):

- Monitoring (tracking, surveillance)
- Evaluation (ratings, performance scores)
- Discipline (deactivation, penalties)

Indicators:

- Monitoring: GPS tracking, screenshots, activity logs
- Evaluation: customer ratings, acceptance rate requirements
- Discipline: account deactivation, reduced order flow

Measurement: Interview questions, survey items, or platform policy analysis

How the next 80 minutes will run

About 15 minutes per person:

1. I read your RQ and a simple equation for your study.
2. Your cross-feedback partner opens with one operationalisation question.
3. We open it to the room.
4. You leave with one commitment for A4 (Tuesday 12 May, 11:00).

The equation is just a thinking tool. The form is always the same:

$$\text{Outcome} = \text{effect} \times \text{the thing you think drives it} + (\text{other things})$$

Qualitative version: what is on the left, and what is on the right.

Group A: 12:00–13:20

Text-as-data and cross-national designs

Cross-feedback pairs: Kate ↔ Lea Kseniya ↔ Daniel

Kate Domnikoff: regulatory complexity across GDPR and DMA

Current RQ: How does regulatory complexity across GDPR and DMA shape compliance behaviour among designated gatekeeper platforms?

$$\text{Compliance} = \text{effect} \times \text{Complexity} + (\text{firm size, sector})$$

Discuss with Lea, then with the room:

- What is the **single, concrete** measure of “compliance”? (enforcement decisions, total fines, policy edits, breach notifications)
- How is “complexity” measured? (count of obligations, cross-references between GDPR and DMA, a coded index)
- Sample: the seven DMA gatekeepers? Time window: post-2023 designation, or 2018 to 2025?

Lea Géciová: defensive vs offensive digital sovereignty

Current RQ: How do defensive and offensive forms of digital sovereignty shape internet freedom across OECD states?

$$\text{Internet freedom} = \text{effect}_1 \times \text{Defensive DS} + \text{effect}_2 \times \text{Offensive DS}$$

The whole study is the prediction that effect_1 and effect_2 point in opposite directions: defensive helps freedom, offensive hurts it.

Discuss with Kate, then with the room:

- Which V-Dem DSP items map to defensive vs offensive? (worth an hour with the codebook before A4)
- Does the defensive bucket hold up at 2 items? If not, do you need an external indicator (Open Data Barometer, EU portability)?
- Panel window and country set: 2010 to 2023, OECD only, or OECD plus a comparison set?

Kseniya Sidorenko: digital mobilisation and political prisoner sentencing

Current RQ: Does digital visibility of a defendant's case affect sentencing severity for political prisoners in Russia, and does this change after the 2022 shift to coercive autocracy?

Before 2022: **Sentence length** = $\text{effect}_{\text{before}} \times \text{Visibility}$

After 2022: **Sentence length** = $\text{effect}_{\text{after}} \times \text{Visibility}$

The whole study is whether the two effects have different signs.

Discuss with Daniel, then with the room:

- What counts as “visibility”? (OVD-Info coverage, social-media mentions, Memorial designation, Western press hits)
- Where is the regime cut-point? (24 February 2022, the Security Council meeting on 21 February 2022, or graded by year)
- Sample frame: which case universe? (Memorial list, OVD-Info, court records). Coverage 2012 to 2024?

Daniel Ugarte: digital repression and democratic backsliding in Hungary

Current RQ: Do digitally restrictive laws in Hungary precede declines in V-Dem indicators, and how does the framing of these laws evolve over time?

Two parts to your RQ, so two pictures:

H1 (sequencing): $\text{V-Dem this year} = \text{effect} \times \text{Laws last year}$

H2 (framing): $\text{Discretion of a law} = \text{effect} \times \text{Year passed}$

Discuss with Kseniya, then with the room:

- Hungarian originals, English translations, or machine translation?
- Which legislative source? (National Assembly database, Hungarian Gazette, both)
- Which V-Dem indicators on the backsliding side? (v2x_freexp_altinf, v2x_civlib, v2xcs_ccsi)

Group B: 13:25–14:45

Case, applied, and mixed designs

Cross-feedback pairs: Anand ↔ Vince Francis ↔ Louiza

Anand Dev Esponda: media ownership concentration and Gen Z distrust

Current RQ: Does concentration of online platform ownership in the US shape political distrust among Gen Z?

$$\text{Distrust} = \text{effect} \times \text{Concentration exposure} + (\text{demographics, media use})$$

Discuss with Vince, then with the room:

- **First decision:** which population are you actually sampling? US-based Gen Z, or expats in NL? The RQ and the sample frame have to match.
- How is “concentration exposure” captured? (named-platform checklist, hours per outlet, ownership-mapped index)
- Distrust scale: ANES institutional-trust items, or a custom Likert? Pilot with 5 students before the full 80?

Vince Kromberg: platform Terms of Service and regulatory shocks

Current RQ: How do platform Terms of Service change in response to regulatory shocks (GDPR 2018, P2B 2019, DMA 2024) on freelance platforms?

$$\text{ToS clause score} = \text{effect}_1 \times \text{After GDPR} + \text{effect}_2 \times \text{After P2B} + \text{effect}_3 \times \text{After DMA}$$

Each “After” is a yes/no flag. The story is which effects are big, and in which direction.

Discuss with Anand, then with the room:

- **First, the Wayback check:** do snapshots exist for Upwork, Fiverr, AMT at 2017, 2019, and 2024?
- Coding scheme: what counts as a “data-collection clause” vs an “account-termination clause”? Inter-coder reliability check?
- Snapshots per platform per period: one (closest to event) or several (averaged)?

Francis van Luyn: Digital Silk Road and ASEAN sovereignty

Current RQ: How does Chinese-built digital infrastructure affect digital sovereignty across ASEAN member states?

Digital sovereignty = effect $\times$ **Chinese infrastructure (a few years earlier)**

The lag matters: lock-in does not happen instantly.

Discuss with Louiza, then with the room:

- **First decision (RQ):** commit to digital sovereignty OR internet freedom; remove the alternative.
- Which AidData layers count? (physical, data, application, all of them)
- Which sovereignty indicator? (V-Dem DSP, Freedom House FOTN, custom index). Lag length: 1, 3, or 5 years?

Louiza Reysen: digital accessibility of German municipal websites

Current RQ: What explains variation in the digital accessibility of German municipal government websites?

$$\text{Accessibility} = \text{effect}_1 \times \text{Size} + \text{effect}_2 \times \text{In-house IT} + \text{effect}_3 \times \text{Political control}$$

The Bundesland is a control, not an explanation.

Discuss with Francis, then with the room:

- Accessibility measure: WCAG audit by an automated tool (SiteImprove, axe), a manual sample of pages, or both?
- Sample: random N around 80, or all state capitals plus a stratified sample of smaller municipalities?
- Where do you find IT in-house vs outsourced data? (municipal procurement records, FOI request, a survey)

Privacy Forms

Important

Submit privacy forms and checklists next week. I must sign these before you begin data collection.

- Applies to all students collecting data involving human participants
- Interviews, surveys, and observations all require privacy documentation
- Templates are on Canvas

For Next Week (Meeting 4, May 13)

Submit C1–C3 (focus on C3) by Tuesday 10:59 via Canvas:

- Chapter 3: **Methodology**
 - Research strategy (qualitative, quantitative, mixed)
 - Data collection methods and instruments
 - Sampling strategy and justification
 - Operationalization table
 - Ethical considerations
- Also: submit **privacy forms and checklists**

Key References

Operationalization and measurement:

- Bryman, A. (2016). *Social Research Methods*, Ch. 7. OUP.
- Neuman, W.L. (2014). *Social Research Methods*, Ch. 7. Pearson.

Validity and reliability:

- Creswell, J.W. (2014). *Research Design*, Ch. 9–10. Sage.
- King, Keohane & Verba (1994). *Designing Social Inquiry*. Princeton UP.

Substantive:

- Wood, A.J. et al. (2019). Good gig, bad gig. *Work, Employment and Society*, 33(1), 56–75.
- Kenney, M. & Zysman, J. (2016). The rise of the platform economy. *Issues in Science and Technology*, 32(3).

Questions?

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